successful bids for independence: the Hoysala and Seuna, Kakatiya and Kalachuri, all fighting for control of their own lands.

In 1157, the Kalachuri king Bijjala II scored a great victory, capturing the Western Chalukya capital Kalyani and forcing the Western Chalukya king himself to flee. Like Parakrama Bahu to the south, Bijjala II now governed a fragmented kingdom that encompassed more than one previous kingdom. Unlike Parakrama, he was unable to use religion to build a fence around it.

Not long after the conquest of Kalyani, Bijjala II's trusted prime minister Baladeva died. Following the minister's own dying recommendation, Bijjala II recruited Baladeva's nephew as the new prime minister over the freshly expanded kingdom. This nephew, still only in his midtwenties, had already gained a reputation for both piety and intelligence. His name was Basava, and after considering the pros and cons of the appointment for some time, he decided to accept it and moved to Kalyani.[10]

Bijjala had no idea that he had recruited a zealot. According to Basava's later biography, the *Basava purano*, Basava took the position only because it would give him the power to spread his own particular message. He was a devotee of Shiva; and not just a devotee, but a fanatic. To Basava, Shiva was the *only* deity, sustaining all the world, equally present with and gracious to all men and women. He had gathered around him a sect of like-minded worshippers, all of whom wore a tiny *lingam* suspended from a cord around their necks or left arms. Nicknamed *lingayats*, *lingam* wearers, these disciples devoted themselves to finding a greater love for God; for them, all of their labor in the world was worship of Shiva, who had created the material world and was honored by their work within it. As one follower wrote,

